A 2,000-YEAR-OLD RULE

Rome's first emperor had a rule for speed.

Two words. Still useful for anyone building in a hurry.

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THE WORDS

σπεῦδε βραδέως

“Hurry slowly.”

WHO SAID IT

Augustus, as quoted by Suetonius, 2nd century CE

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Source: Suetonius, Life of Augustus 25.4 (Loeb Classical Library 1913, via LacusCurtius)

Hurry. Don't rush.

Augustus thought nothing suited a good commander less than haste and rashness. His other favourite line: “That is done quickly enough which is done well enough.”

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Source: Suetonius, Life of Augustus 25.4 (Loeb Classical Library 1913, via LacusCurtius)

From a Roman coin to a printer's mark.

In Latin: festina lente. By 1502 the Venetian printer Aldus Manutius used a dolphin wrapped around an anchor, a design also found on coins of Emperor Titus. Erasmus read it as speed and stability.

Source: Grolier Club, Aldus Manutius exhibition (the device, the Titus coin, Erasmus' reading)

Be fast where you can undo it. Be slow where you can't.

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I'VE SAT AT THAT TABLE

Term sheets signed in a rush often get reopened in due diligence.

What did slowing down save you? Or what did rushing cost you?

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Sources: Suetonius, Life of Augustus 25.4 (Loeb 1913, via LacusCurtius) · Grolier Club, Aldus Manutius exhibition

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